

Aquifer Open Study Notes (Themes)

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This resource has been adapted into multiple languages, including English, Tok Pisin, Arabic (عربي), French (Français), Hindi (हिंदी), Indonesian (Bahasa Indonesia), Portuguese (Português), Russian (Русский), Spanish (Español), Swahili (Kiswahili), and Simplified Chinese (简体中文).

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Calling up the Dead

The Old Testament forbids magical practices like spiritism, divination, and necromancy. Necromancy involves contacting dead spirits, usually to seek future guidance (see Deuteronomy 18:9–12). Practicing necromancy and consulting a necromancer were crimes punishable by death (Leviticus 20:6, 27; compare 1 Samuel 28:9). Instead, God’s people must rely on God for guidance.

God buried Moses in an unmarked grave (Deuteronomy 34:6). He probably did this to prevent the Israelites from turning Moses’ grave into an idolatrous place of worship. God did not want them to present offerings to Moses’ spirit, worship him, or try to contact his spirit. There might have been a temptation for the Israelites to do these things. This was because they experienced the Egyptians practice these things. Also, Moses’ important role in mediating Israel’s covenant with God could tempt them to practice unhealthy veneration of his memory.

The Old Testament states that people cannot contact the dead (see 2 Samuel 12:23; Job 14:10–12; Psalms 88:10; 115:17). The prophet Samuel is the only known exception. It seems that God told him to return and speak (see 1 Samuel 28:12–19). When Saul tried to contact Samuel through someone who claimed to speak with the dead (a medium), this sin was very serious. The writer of Chronicles highlights this failure when explaining why Saul lost his kingdom (see 1 Chronicles 10:13–14). There is never a reason to practice necromancy (to seek advice from the dead) when we have God’s living word to guide us (2 Timothy 3:15–17; Hebrews 4:12–13).

Passages for Further Study

Leviticus 19:31; 20:6–8, 27; Deuteronomy 18:9–12; 1 Samuel 28:1–25; 2 Kings 21:6; 23:24; 1 Chronicles 10:13–14; Job 14:10–12; Isaiah 3:1–3; 8:19–22

Canaanite Religion

The Canaanites explained creation or nature in relation to their gods. Each god represented a natural force. They considered the moon, sun, important stars, and visible planets as gods or goddesses.

Canaanite gods had two notable aspects:

1. Their personalities could change.
2. Their names related to their roles.

Some of these gods had great influence in the Israelites’ interactions with the Canaanite people:

1. El means “the powerful one.” He was the leader of the Canaanite gods. El lived far from Canaan, “at the source of the two rivers” (this may refer to the garden of Eden). He led a council of gods who were his children. In the Old Testament, El (plural Elohim) refers to God, but the Israelite God is not the same as the Canaanite god.
2. Baal means “lord.” He was the great storm god and king of the gods. Though El was the leader, Baal had more active power as El’s second in command. He provided all fertility. When Baal died, plants stopped growing and animals stopped reproducing. He was the god of justice and caused fear for those doing wrong.
3. Dagon means “fish” or “grain.” He is sometimes called the father of Baal. Dagon was the main god of the Philistine city of Ashdod (1 Samuel 5:1–7).
4. Ashtoreth, Anath, and Asherah were the three main goddesses in the Canaanite group of gods. They focused mainly on sex and war. Their primary role was to have yearly sexual relations with Baal. This maintained Baal’s strength and guaranteed the earth would be fertile.

The Canaanites believed that the forces of nature were like people. These gods controlled the changing seasons. From April to October, they saw the dry period as Baal’s death after losing a battle each spring. The autumn rains marked Baal’s revival as the god of rain and plants, lasting until the next April. They thought the land became fertile again because of Baal’s yearly mating with his female partner. Their religious activities included imitating their gods’ actions.

The Canaanites worshiped things they believed would bring them material benefits. If this pleased the gods and goddesses, they would provide a good harvest. If a god became angry, the people might offer animal or human sacrifices to calm the god (see 2 Kings 3:26–27). Canaanite worship had its basis in fear and trying to influence or pacify the gods.

Contact among the many religions of the ancient Near East led to social problems and borrowing religious practices. The Arameans and Philistines who settled in Canaan adopted Canaanite practices. In a similar way, the Amorites included Sumerian religious practices when they moved into Mesopotamia.

In contrast, Israel’s God, Yahweh, required complete loyalty. His worship had its basis in faith, not fear. Unfortunately, the Israelites did not keep their belief in one God (monotheism). They adopted pagan ideas

and practices, worshiping Canaanite gods in their way. Their culture became corrupted and angered God. As a result, God judged them and sent them into exile (see 2 Kings 17:5–23; 24:18–25:21).

Passages for Further Study

1 Samuel 5:1–12

Celebration

God welcomes happy expressions of joy and delight from those who worship and praise him (Isaiah 30:29; Jeremiah 30:19; 31:13; Zephaniah 3:17; Ephesians 5:19; Colossians 3:16).

King David tried two times to bring the ark of God (also called the ark of the LORD or the ark of the covenant) to Jerusalem (2 Samuel 6:1–11, 12–23). Both times involved celebration.

Four different Hebrew words describe how Israel and David rejoiced. Their joy included leaping, dancing, and playing music (see also 1 Chronicles 15:25–29). The four Hebrew words are:

1. *karar*, which means “to dance” (2 Samuel 6:14, 16);
2. *pazaz*, which means “to leap” (translated as “dancing” in the Berean Standard Bible in 2 Samuel 6:16);
3. *raqad*, which also means “to leap” (again translated as “dancing” in the Berean Standard Bible in 1 Chronicles 15:29); and
4. *sakhaq*, which means more generally “to rejoice”, and which can suggest dancing, singing, and music (2 Samuel 6:5; 1 Chronicles 15:29).

Together, these words show that their celebration included joyful movement with their bodies.

Musical instruments were important in temple worship. In 1 Chronicles 25:1–31, David assigned groups to music ministry. Many psalms mention playing instruments to praise and worship God (see Psalms 33:2–3; 57:8; 81:2; 92:1–3; 98:4–6). In Psalms 149 and 150, dance and music are combined as a praise offering. In a similar way, music and dancing were present in the father’s house in the parable of the lost son (Luke 15:25). This was because the son’s return was a joyful event.

The book of Revelation describes an eternal celebration for the faithful. This celebration involves worship in God’s presence (Revelation 4:1–11; 5:8–14; 15:1–4). It is like a wedding feast where the bridegroom (Jesus Christ) and the bride (his church) unite forever (Revelation 19:9; see also Matthew 22:1–14).

Passages for Further Study

Exodus 5:1; 12:17; 15:20–21; 1 Samuel 18:6; 2 Samuel 6:1–15; 2 Chronicles 7:6–10; Ezra 3:10–11; Psalms 30:11; 69:30; 98:4–6; 107:32; 149:1–9; 150:1–6; Isaiah 30:29; 54:1; Jeremiah 30:18–19; 31:4, 13; Lamentations 5:14–15; Zephaniah 3:17; Luke 15:22–25; 1 Corinthians 5:8; Ephesians 5:18–20; Colossians 3:16; Revelation 18:20

The Central Sanctuary

God wanted people to worship where he had chosen to put his name. For Israel, this was first the tabernacle and later the temple in Jerusalem.

God is transcendent (above all things) and omnipresent (present everywhere). Yet he chose a specific place for Israel to worship him. King Solomon later asked how the God of heaven could live in a building made by humans (1 Kings 8:27). The answer is that God’s name represents himself.

The tabernacle and later the temple belonged to him and his name marked them. So they were, in a way, his homes. In the ancient Near East, names were more than just labels. They showed the character and nature of the person (for example, Jacob, Genesis 27:36; Jesus, Matthew 1:21; Barnabas, Acts 4:36; Peter, Matthew 16:17–19). Thus, Solomon could advise, “A good name is more desirable than great riches” (Proverbs 22:1).

God lived in a holy place that carried his name. His glorious presence appeared as fire and cloud during the time Israel lived in the wilderness. This acted as a constant reminder that he was with his people (Exodus 40:34–35). Similarly, when Solomon established the temple, God’s presence was also evident (1 Kings 8:10–11).

God later lived among his people as Jesus Christ (John 1:14). This removed the need for a central holy place (see John 4:19–24). Now, because the Holy Spirit lives within them, all Christians can “house” God’s presence (1 Corinthians 3:16–17; 6:19–20; 2 Corinthians 6:16; Ephesians 2:21).

Passages for Further Study

Exodus 25:8–9, 22, 40; 26:30; 33:7–11; 40:34–35; Numbers 7:1; 11:16; Deuteronomy 12:4–7; 31:14–15; 1 Kings 8:10–11, 27; John 1:14; 2:19–21; Acts 7:44; 1 Corinthians 3:16–17; 6:19–20; 2 Corinthians 6:16; Ephesians 2:21; Hebrews 8:2, 5; Revelation 21:22

Charismatic Leadership

Scripture describes some leaders as charismatic (gifted) because their authority came from God’s Spirit. God’s Spirit gave them special qualities.

The Old Testament judges are often part of this group. These charismatic leaders emerged during troubled times in response to problems. In the book of Judges, these problems often happened because the Israelites “did evil in the sight of the LORD.” This led to enemies oppressing Israel (Judges 3:12; 4:1; 6:1; Judges 10:6; 13:1).

The leadership of the judges followed a pattern. God’s Spirit “came upon” a judge and prophetic support sustained them. At other times in Israel’s history, God gave prophetic messages (for example, 1 Samuel 10:6; 2 Samuel 23:2; Isaiah 61:1; Ezekiel 11:5; Micah 3:8). In the time of the judges, the Spirit at times gave physical strength (for example, to Samson in Judges 14:6, 19; 15:14). The Spirit also sometimes gave skill or leadership power to judges (Judges 3:10; 6:34; 11:29).

Jesus and the apostles led people through spiritual power. The Jewish leaders often pointed out that Jesus had no “official” title or authority, yet he showed great power and gained many followers. The apostles were appointed to positions we might call “offices.” While the early church had some basic organization, it was not as structured as it would later become. The authority of the apostles was a gift from the Holy Spirit. Peter’s healing of the beggar indicates the difference between material wealth, like “silver or gold,” and true spiritual power (Acts 3:1–8).

Throughout history, from ancient Israel until today, many leaders have shown God’s power working through them. This kind of leadership depends on God’s Spirit giving them special qualities. But if leaders stop following God’s Spirit, they can lose these special qualities (see Judges 16:20–21; 1 Samuel 16:14; Isaiah 63:10). Leaders gifted by the Spirit must always remain aware of and rely on that same Spirit.

Passages for Further Study

Exodus 31:2–5; Judges 2:16–19; 3:10, 27–28; 6:34–35; 11:29; 14:6, 19; 15:14; 1 Samuel 10:6; 16:13–18; 2 Samuel 23:2; Isaiah 61:1; Ezekiel 11:5; Micah 3:8; Matthew 3:16–4:2; Acts 6:8; 8:4–40; Romans 1:11; 12:6–8; 1 Corinthians 12:4–11; Ephesians 4:11–12

Children and Parents

Wise children bring great joy to their parents, while foolish children cause them much grief (Proverbs 10:1; 15:20; 17:21, 25). This motivates parents to guide their children toward wisdom and encourages children to listen to wise advice (19:26–27).

When children need discipline, parents should not avoid their responsibility, as this can harm the child (Proverbs 19:18; 22:15; 23:13–14). Parents should teach

their children about the Lord through their own wise and moral behavior (Deuteronomy 6:1–25; Proverbs 20:7; 22:6). They should also tell them about God’s great acts in history (Psalm 78:1–8). This knowledge will guide children to obedience and blessings. Children should respect their godly parents (Proverbs 20:20; 30:11–14, 17).

Proverbs focuses on the strength and influence of a united family that loves and obeys God. The book strongly warns against those who would harm a family (Proverbs 6:16–19; 11:29). It greatly praises those who strengthen the family (see 14:1). A family that relies on the Lord can truly thrive (Psalms 127–128).

Passages for Further Study

Deuteronomy 5:16; 6:1–9, 20–25; 7:3–6; Psalms 78:1–8; 103:13; 127:1–128:6; Proverbs 1:8–9; 3:1–2; 4:1–4; 10:1; 11:21, 29; 12:7; 13:22; 14:1; 15:20; 17:21, 25; 19:18, 26; 20:7, 20; 22:6, 15; 23:13–14; 29:15, 17; 30:11–14, 17; Mark 7:9–13; Luke 1:17; 18:29–30; Ephesians 6:1–4

The Choice of Life or Death

Moses instructed the Israelites as they were about to enter the promised land. They had a choice. They could obey the covenant, which is life as God designed it, and live. Or they could refuse to obey the creator’s design and die (Deuteronomy 30:19). This choice and its consequences continued throughout the time of God’s covenant with Israel.

The specific language of Deuteronomy 30 appears again in the prophecy of Jeremiah during the Babylonian invasion. God said, “Behold, I set before you the way of life and the way of death” (Jeremiah 21:8). The prophet warned King Zedekiah and his people to obey the Lord’s instruction. If they obeyed, they would live, if not, they would die.

Earlier in Jeremiah’s prophetic ministry, the Lord gave the people of Judah a chance to repent (Jeremiah 3:12–4:4). They must stop idol worship, admit their guilt, and confess their rebellion. Then God would cleanse their minds and hearts. He would allow them to live peacefully in the land. Yet, the people continued to reject this offer (Jeremiah 7:5–7; 18:8–11; 23:22; 26:13; 27:12–13; 29:32; 35:15; 36:3–7; 44:5). So the Lord continued to warn them that rejecting the path of life would lead to judgment.

In Jeremiah’s time, only a few chose life. Most rebelled and died. Ultimately, the people led by King Zedekiah ignored the Lord. They rebelled against the Babylonian army, and suffered judgment. They deliberately rejected the gift of life.

Passages for Further Study

Deuteronomy 11:26–29; 30:15–20; Proverbs 9:1–18; 11:19; 18:21; Isaiah 1:19–20; Jeremiah 3:12–15; 4:3–4; 7:5–7; 18:7–11; 21:8–9; 23:22; 26:13; 27:12–18; 35:15; 36:3–7; 44:5; Ezekiel 18:23–24; Romans 6:23; 8:6; Revelation 2:10

The Christ Hymn: Christ's Divine Nature

The passage in Philippians 2:6–11 is often called the Christ Hymn. This section reveals what early Christians believed about Jesus Christ. The hymn shows that early Christians believed Jesus existed before his birth on earth and that he has a divine nature (see also Colossians 1:15–20; 2:9; compare John 1:1–2; Hebrews 1:1–3).

The hymn teaches that Christ is not just another human prophet. He was with God the Father from the beginning. He is the one through whom God created the universe. As the Son of God, Jesus shares God's own nature.

This claim about Jesus being divine caused major disagreements between Jesus and the religious leaders of his time. They accused Jesus of blasphemy (speaking in a way that dishonors God) when he claimed to be equal with God (John 5:16–18; 8:54–59; 10:30–39).

The hymn also teaches that Jesus Christ came to earth in an act of great humility. The infinite God (who is eternal and not bound by time) took on human nature in the person of Jesus Christ and entered human history (Philippians 2:7; see Colossians 1:15; John 1:10–14; Hebrews 2:14, 17). Jesus Christ, the glorious Creator of the universe, died as a sacrifice for the sins of human beings. This was to secure forgiveness and reconcile humanity with God (Philippians 2:8; see John 3:14–17; Romans 5:9–10; Colossians 1:20, 22; 2:13–14; Hebrews 1:3; 10:9–14). The Scriptures had prophesied this very thing (see Isaiah 53:3–12).

This hymn states that God raised Jesus from the dead and gave him the highest honor in heaven (Philippians 2:9). God also gave him the title “Lord” (Philippians 2:11; compare Colossians 1:18). One day, all created beings will bow before him and acknowledge him as Lord of the universe (Philippians 2:9–11). He deserves the worship that only God is worthy to receive (see Revelation 5:8–14).

Passages for Further Study

Isaiah 53:3–12; John 1:1–2, 10–14; 3:14–17; Romans 5:9–10; Philippians 2:6–11; Colossians 1:15–22; 2:9, 13–14; Hebrews 1:1–3; 2:14, 17; 10:9–14; Revelation 5:8–14

Christian Giving

Generous Christian giving shows true grace. We see this in “our Lord Jesus Christ, that though He was rich, yet for your sakes He became poor, so that you through His poverty might become rich” (2 Corinthians 8:9; Philippians 2:5–8). We have received his undeserved favor in salvation, and we give generously in response to “His indescribable gift!” (2 Corinthians 9:15).

Jesus taught that generosity shows who follows him (Matthew 25:34–36). He emphasized the importance of a person's intentions and attitude, not only the amount given (Mark 12:41–44).

In 2 Corinthians, the apostle Paul emphasizes the theme of giving. He encourages the church at Corinth to give generously to help those in need, especially the poor Jewish Christians in Jerusalem (2 Corinthians 8:6–7; 9:1–5). This generosity would show that gentile Christians and Jewish Christians in Jerusalem are part of the same “body.”

Here is a summary of Paul's teachings about Christian giving:

1. Our giving should come from a willing mind and heart (2 Corinthians 8:12; 9:7). Paul emphasizes motives because the reason behind our giving is most important.
2. True giving brings joy, unlike reluctant gifts (2 Corinthians 9:5). When we give to others, it brings joy, just as a farmer is happy when planting (sowing seed) because they know crops will grow (9:6–10). Sharing with those in need also brings joy (9:1–2).
3. Christian giving is generous and may involve sacrifice, as shown by the Macedonians (2 Corinthians 8:1–5).
4. Handling financial gifts requires honesty, integrity, and care. Paul was careful to protect his colleagues who collected gifts from the churches from suspicion (2 Corinthians 8:20–21). People managing church donations should have a proven reputation and responsibility.

Christian living should show a generous concern for those in need. Paul instructs Christians to please God, not themselves (2 Corinthians 5:15). Christians should live under Jesus' leadership and his love should motivate them (5:14). We can show his love clearly through our giving.

Passages for Further Study

Exodus 25:2; 35:5; Leviticus 25:35; Deuteronomy 15:7–11; 16:17; 1 Chronicles 29:9; Proverbs 3:9–10; 11:24–26; 21:13; 28:27; Malachi 3:8; Matthew 5:42; 6:3–4; 10:8; 19:21; Luke

6:38; 11:41; 12:33–34; 18:22; Acts 11:29; 1 Corinthians 13:3; 16:2–3; 2 Corinthians 5:17–18; 2 Corinthians 8:1–9:15; Philippians 2:3–11

Christian Joy

In the final hours of his life, Jesus wanted his disciples filled with his joy (see John 15:11; 16:20–24). Joy is a common topic in many of the apostle Paul's letters and is a key theme in Philippians. Paul often encourages Christians to be joyful, especially those facing persecution, like the Christians in Philippi and Thessalonica (Philippians 3:1; 4:4; 1 Thessalonians 5:16).

Surface-level happiness depends on what is happening around you. Christian joy is different. It comes from a person's relationship with the Lord. It remains strong even during suffering and death. Joy comes from knowing that whatever happens, God will use everything for a Christian's ultimate good (see Romans 5:3–4; 8:28).

Christians also find joy in the active presence of God's Spirit in their hearts (see Galatians 5:22). The real secret to a joyful life is "to be filled with the Holy Spirit" (see Ephesians 5:18). A relationship with the living God forms Christians' attitudes, not external circumstances.

Passages for Further Study

John 15:11; 16:24; Romans 5:3–4; 8:28; Galatians 5:22; Ephesians 5:18; Philippians 3:1; 4:4; 1 Thessalonians 5:16

Christian Suffering

We should not be surprised when we experience suffering (1 Peter 4:12). Christians who live differently by obeying God should expect the culture to respond with hostility. We should expect mockery, bad treatment, false accusations, and even violence.

God has a purpose for us in suffering. It unites us further to Christ, who suffered before God glorified him (1 Peter 4:13; see also Romans 8:17). By suffering with Christ, we can be sure of sharing in the glory he has already achieved.

The Letter of 1 Peter emphasizes Christian suffering, especially unfair persecution by those who are against the Christian faith. These themes of suffering are most clearly explained in 4:12–19.

We need to commit to doing what is right when we experience suffering (1 Peter 4:19). Difficulties can often become excuses for sinning. But during difficult times, we must live as good examples by showing love for others. Our loving response to enemies during

times of distress can be a powerful chance to share our Christian faith. When we show love and kindness to those who hurt us, others may become interested in our faith.

We should remember during our distresses that it is "God's will" and he is "faithful" (1 Peter 4:19). He controls all of life's circumstances. So we do not need to fear any distress as if it could be outside God's oversight or will.

Passages for Further Study

Isaiah 48:10; 52:13–53:12; 63:7–9; Mark 10:35–40; Acts 5:41; 9:16; 14:22; Romans 8:17–23; 2 Corinthians 1:5–7; 4:10; 12:10; Philippians 1:29; Colossians 1:24; 1 Thessalonians 2:14; 2 Thessalonians 1:5; 2 Timothy 3:12; Hebrews 2:9–10; 5:8; 13:12; James 5:11–13; 1 Peter 4:12–19

The Church

The church is the community of people who acknowledge Christ as Lord and obey him (Ephesians 5:21–24). The New Testament word for "church" comes from the Greek word *ekklēsia* (meaning "a group of people who gather together"). In the Greek-speaking world, this word was used for different types of meetings. It could mean a formal political meeting or just an informal gathering of people (for example, Acts 19:32, 39, 41). In the Septuagint (the Greek translation of the Old Testament), the term refers to when the community of Israel met (for example, Deuteronomy 31:30).

In the New Testament, *ekklēsia* refers to:

1. The entire body of Christ worldwide (for example, Matthew 16:18; Ephesians 1:22)
2. All Christians in a specific area (for example, Acts 9:31; 1 Corinthians 1:2)
3. A local community that meets regularly for worship, teaching, fellowship, and prayer (for example, Romans 16:5; see Acts 2:42)

The New Testament uses several concepts to describe the church:

1. The Israel of God (Galatians 6:16): Those who are "God's own possession" (1 Peter 2:9–10). They serve as "a holy priesthood, offering spiritual sacrifices acceptable to God" (1 Peter 2:5, 9).
2. God's family (Ephesians 2:19; 1 Timothy 3:15): This consists of those adopted as God's spiritual children and named as his heirs.
3. A holy temple: The place God lives by his Spirit (Ephesians 2:21–22; 4:6; 1 Corinthians 3:16–17; 2 Corinthians 6:16; Colossians 1:27).
4. Body of Christ: They represent Christ fully in the world, with Christ as the leader (Ephesians 1:23;

4:15; 5:23–24; 1 Corinthians 12:12–27; Colossians 1:18, 24).

5. Christ's pure bride: The one he died for, cares for, and cherishes. She will live with him forever in unity. (Ephesians 5:25–29).

The church is part of God's plan to unite everything in heaven and on earth under Christ's authority (Ephesians 1:9–10). Through Jesus Christ, God has called people from both Judaism and the non-Jewish world (gentile) to become one new people of God (Galatians 6:16). They are empowered by his Spirit to be present in the world, worship him, and share the good news (gospel) of his unconditional love (Ephesians 2:11–22).

The spiritual roots of the church are in Judaism. The church fulfills God's intention for Israel to be "a light for the nations" and to "bring My salvation to the ends of the earth" (Isaiah 49:6; see also Romans 11:1–5). In this new community of Jewish and non-Jewish believers, Jesus breaks down all the old divisions between people. No one is considered better or worse than others because of their ethnic background, social position, or whether they are male or female (Galatians 3:28).

Those united with Christ are members of his body. Paul describes the close connection between Christ and his people as similar to the unity of a physical body (Romans 12:4–8; 1 Corinthians 12:12–27). Being "in Christ" means "baptized into one body" (1 Corinthians 12:12–13). As a result, "you are the body of Christ, and each of you is a member of it" (1 Corinthians 12:27).

Christians connect with God as part of a new family. Being "in Christ" means being part of the church. Being a Christian means joining a community committed to express Christ's reality in its shared life.

Since the church is one body, unity is necessary. Paul often encouraged Christians to stay united and not let differences separate them.

The church includes people from different ethnic groups, so it should be a community of harmony and peace. Christians should live together in love, united by their shared experience of the Holy Spirit (Ephesians 4:2–6). God's goal for the church is to reach complete unity, faith, spiritual understanding, and Christian maturity. He intends for the full perfection of Christ (4:13, 15; compare Romans 8:29). The church must reflect God's likeness (Ephesians 4:24, 32; 5:1).

Just like each part of the human body has a role, each church member has a function. God has given people in the church various gifts to strengthen the commu-

nity and help it reach its full potential (Ephesians 4:11–16; Romans 12:6–8; 1 Corinthians 12:7–11, 28).

God intends for the church to display his forgiving grace (Ephesians 2:7; 3:10). It should be a community where people can see God's glory, committed to praising that glory (3:21; 5:18–20).

Passages for Further Study

Romans 8:29; 12:6–8; 1 Corinthians 3:16–17; 6:16; 12:7–28; Galatians 6:16; Ephesians 1:9–10, 23; 2:7; 2:14–3:13; 4:2–6, 11–16; 5:18–20, 23–29; Colossians 1:18, 24, 27; 1 Timothy 3:15; 1 Peter 2:5, 9–10

The Church as a Living, Active Body

The apostle Paul considered the church as the living body of Jesus Christ made up of believers. Paul did not make any formal difference between professional church leaders and ordinary members, where only the leaders did the ministry work. The community had leaders (see, for example, 1 Timothy 3:1–13). But every Christian could contribute to building up the body (1 Corinthians 12:12–31). The early Christians usually gathered together in someone's home, and everyone could share a gift from God with others (14:26–33).

Paul understood that God's Spirit gives people special gifts for their specific ministries (1 Corinthians 2:7–11, 28; Romans 12:6–8; Ephesians 4:11). The Holy Spirit leads them when they come together for worship. Guided by the Spirit, every believer should use their spiritual gifts to help the church. Paul wanted believers to be aware of the Spirit's power in everything they did (1 Corinthians 14:26–33).

When Christians gather, every person is important and has an active role to play. Christians must listen for God speaking his word and be ready to speak it in all their relationships. Paul also calls for others to "weigh carefully" (or evaluate) what is said (1 Corinthians 14:26, 29). Every Christian is a necessary part of the group. Each person is called to actively help it grow.

Passages for Further Study

Romans 12:4–8; 1 Corinthians 12:7–31; 14:26–33; Ephesians 1:23; 4:11–13; Colossians 1:24; 2:18–19; 1 Timothy 3:1–16

The Church as God's Temple

The idea of the church as God's temple comes from the Old Testament. The kings David and Solomon received a promise that the temple in Jerusalem would be where God lived among his people (see 2 Samuel 7:12–16; 1 Kings 9:1–9). Solomon finished the temple in 960 BC. The Babylonians destroyed it in 586 BC. But

the prophets of Israel anticipated a new temple. They shared a hopeful message that God would live among his people again (see, for example, Isaiah 56:7; Ezekiel 40–43).

The Israelites rebuilt the temple in Jerusalem after the exile when they returned from Babylon. It reached its peak during Herod the Great's additions. But the arrival of Jesus Christ truly fulfilled the hopes of God's people (see John 1:14; 2:19–22; 4:21–24). Jesus is God's temple, where God's holiness lives. God invites his people to join him. Therefore, God's people should be a holy temple, a home for the Holy Spirit (see 1 Corinthians 3:16–17; 6:19; 2 Corinthians 6:16; Ephesians 2:21; 1 Peter 2:5; Revelation 3:12).

The apostle Paul urged Christians to understand their identity as God's holy people (called "saints" in 2 Corinthians 1:1). They should avoid moral evil and commit themselves to holy living and service to God. Paul encourages Christians to "cleanse ourselves from everything that defiles body and spirit, perfecting holiness in the fear of God" (7:1).

Passages for Further Study

2 Samuel 7:12–16; 1 Kings 8:12–53; 2 Chronicles 6:20; Psalms 11:4; 27:4–6; Zechariah 6:12–15; Matthew 18:20; John 2:18–22; 14:20; 17:23; Romans 8:10; 1 Corinthians 3:10–17; 6:18–20; 9:11–14; 2 Corinthians 6:14–7:1; Galatians 2:20; Ephesians 2:20–22; 3:17–19; Colossians 1:27; Hebrews 3:6; 12:18–24; 1 Peter 2:4–9; Revelation 1:12–16; 3:12, 20; 21:22

Church Leaders

The first church gatherings were spontaneous and God's spirit gave gifts in a special way (see 1 Corinthians 14:26–33). The apostles generally led the Christian communities along with the elders in Jerusalem (Acts 6:2; 8:14; 14:23; Acts 15:4, 6, 22–23). Jewish synagogue and Greco-Roman models influenced their roles. The titles and roles of Christian leaders outside Jerusalem were flexible (for example Acts 6:1–6; 13:1–3). But local leaders depended on the apostles when possible.

Teachers and prophets had key roles in church meetings (see Acts 11:27–30; 1 Corinthians 14:26–40). Apostles often started churches before they appointed "elders" (Titus 1:5; Acts 14:23). These appointments were based on spiritual gifts and sometimes on age (see 1 Corinthians 12:28–30; Ephesians 4:11–13).

Community leaders probably existed even without formal titles. In the letters to Timothy and Titus, there is a strong focus on the roles of overseer (bishop), elder (presbyter), and deacon. How these roles developed over time is unclear. The practices in 1 Timothy

and Titus might not have been widespread. Elders in Ephesus and Crete may have had more teaching duties to oppose false teachers.

Otherwise, the issues suggested in 1 Corinthians 14:26–33 might have continued. These letters focus on ensuring the gospel is shared accurately.

The apostle Paul influenced and guided the people and places where he shared the good news. But there is no evidence that Paul wanted to create a system to govern all the churches in these areas. Paul expected the overseers to continue the gospel teaching and discipline roles under the broader responsibilities and authority of the apostles. As local church leaders, they held real and unique authority in their communities (see 1 Corinthians 5:3–5; 1 Timothy 4:11–16; 5:19–22; 2 Timothy 2:14–19, 25–26; Titus 2:15; 3:10–11). Soon after the apostles died, the church's structure became more centralized around the bishop's office, as shown in early second-century Christian writings.

Passages for Further Study

Acts 6:1–6; 13:1–3; 14:23; 15:4–35; 1 Corinthians 12:28–30; 14:26–33; Ephesians 4:11–13; 1 Timothy 3:1–13; 4:11–16; 5:17–22; 2 Timothy 2:2, 25–26; Titus 1:5–9; 2:15

Circumcision

Many ancient cultures practiced circumcision, the removal of the male foreskin (see Jeremiah 9:25–26).

God chose circumcision as a sign of a covenant (special agreement) that focuses on descendants. God promised to make Abraham and his descendants into a great nation and to use them to redeem the non-Jewish nations (Genesis 12:2, 3; 17:3–6; see Galatians 3:8–9). Circumcision was God's mark on the body. It identified Abraham and his descendants as God's people (Genesis 17:9–14). It reminded them to live faithfully to the covenant.

They performed circumcision on adult males when they joined the covenant community (Genesis 17:23–27; Exodus 12:48; Joshua 5:3–7). But it was usually for infants (Genesis 21:4; Leviticus 12:3). Infants received God's promises and joined the covenant community through their parents.

Faith was necessary to receive God's blessings. This was shown by the differences between Ishmael and Isaac, Esau and Jacob, and Joseph and his brothers. Non-Israelites could also join Israel's covenant (Exodus 12:48; compare Genesis 34:15–24). Circumcision marked their inclusion in the worshiping community (for example, Exodus 12:44).

Circumcision helped Israel remember to set aside natural impurity. God's people had to stay loyal to the covenant, their family, and their marriages. Marrying uncircumcised people outside the covenant violated the covenant. The people expelled ("cut off") any man who refused circumcision (a symbolic physical cut) from the covenant people for disobeying God's command (Genesis 17:14).

Circumcision symbolizes separation from the world, purity, and loyalty to the covenant. It offers a strong metaphor for the "circumcision of the heart." This refers to a heart committed to God and set apart for him, rather than being stubbornly resistant (Leviticus 26:41; Deuteronomy 30:6; Jeremiah 4:4; 9:26; Ephesians 2:11). Circumcision of the heart shows salvation and fellowship with God (see Ezekiel 18:31-32; 36:25-27; Romans 2:28-29; 4:11).

When Jesus Christ created God's new covenant, he fulfilled the old covenant's requirements. Gentile Christians do not need circumcision because faith in Jesus makes them part of God's people (Acts 15:1-29; Romans 2:25-29; Galatians 2:1-10; 6:15; Colossians 2:11-12). One must trust in God and his promises, abandon sinful actions and worldly customs, and live a new life by faith (see Jeremiah 31:33-34; Romans 8:1-17; Galatians 5:16-6:10).

Passages for Further Study

Genesis 17:9-14, 23-27; 21:4; 34:1-26; Exodus 4:24-26; 12:48; Leviticus 12:3; Joshua 5:2-8; Jeremiah 9:25-26; Ezekiel 44:7-9; Luke 1:59; 2:21; Acts 15:1-31; 16:1-5; Romans 2:25-29; 1 Corinthians 7:17-19; Galatians 5:1-6, 11-12; 6:12-16; Ephesians 2:11-18; Philippians 3:2-7; Colossians 2:11; 3:11

Circumcision in the New Testament

Circumcision, which is the removal of the male foreskin, was common in the ancient Near East (see Jeremiah 9:25-26). For Jews, it held religious importance as a sign of the covenant (special agreement) God made with the people of Israel (Genesis 17:9-14; Joshua 5:2; John 7:22; Acts 7:8; Sirach 44:20). They usually performed it on the eighth day after a male infant's birth (Genesis 17:12; Leviticus 12:3; Luke 1:59; Acts 7:8).

The New Testament mentions the circumcision of John the Baptizer, Jesus, and the apostles Paul and Timothy (Luke 1:59; 2:21; Acts 16:2-3; Philippians 3:5). Circumcision also became a symbol for renewing a person's relationship with God (Deuteronomy 10:16; 30:6; Jeremiah 4:4; Romans 2:28-29). In the late 40s AD, some Jewish Christians wanted gentile (non-Jewish) Chris-

tians to become circumcised (Acts 15:1, 5; see 21:20-21; Galatians 2:4, 11-13). But Paul and Barnabas disagreed (Acts 15:2). The Church council in Jerusalem decided that gentiles did not need to become circumcised (15:19-21, 28-29).

Paul insisted that it does not matter if a man becomes circumcised (1 Corinthians 7:19). What matters is faith showing itself through love (Galatians 5:6). In Galatians, Paul argued against strong Jewish opponents and stated that everyone joins God's family through faith in Jesus Christ (Galatians 2:14-21). Circumcision is not necessary for God to accept a person (Galatians 5:6). Jesus' death on the cross is how sinners enter into covenant with God (Galatians 2:14-21).

Passages for Further Study

Genesis 17:9-14; Leviticus 12:3; Joshua 5:2-9; Jeremiah 9:25-26; Luke 1:59; Luke 2:21; John 7:22-24; Acts 7:8; Acts 15:1-5, 19-21, 28-31; Acts 16:2-3; Acts 21:18-24; Romans 2:25-29; 1 Corinthians 7:17-19; Galatians 2:3-5, 11-21; Galatians 5:6; Galatians 6:15; Philippians 3:5-9; Colossians 2:11-23

The Cities of Refuge

The Israelites built the cities of refuge to protect innocent people from blood revenge. An avenger had the legal right to kill a murderer (Numbers 35:19; see Genesis 9:6). If someone accidentally caused a death, the person fled to a city of refuge for temporary safety while awaiting trial (Numbers 35:22-28). The six cities of refuge spread across Hebrew territory so any Israelite could seek refuge.

After the trial, if the elders of the city found the person guilty of murder (instead of accidental killing), they handed him over to the avenger for punishment (Deuteronomy 19:12). If they found the person innocent, the killer stayed in the city of refuge for safety. When the high priest died, the killer could return home without fear of blood revenge. This compassionate law prevented the land from pollution by innocent blood (see Numbers 35:33).

Paying a fine to repay the death of a person was not acceptable, even if the death was accidental (Numbers 35:31-33). Human life was too valuable for money to purchase it. When someone killed another person, whether on purpose or by accident, it led to alienation or exile.

Atonement is not easy, whether in ancient Israelite times or today. Everyone needs atonement to restore their relationship with God (see Romans 3:23-26). Jesus, the Son of God, offers this reconciliation. He

acts as the great high priest and died as the ultimate sacrifice (see Hebrews 4:14–10:18).

Passages for Further Study

Numbers 35:6–34; Deuteronomy 19:1–13; Joshua 20:1–9; 21:13, 21, 27, 32, 38; 1 Kings 1:50–53; 2:28–34

Citizenship in the Kingdom

First-century Jews wanted a king like David or leader like Judas Maccabeus to defeat their oppressors. Jesus' idea of the kingdom of God was very different from these hopes (Matthew 5:43–48).

The Gospel of Matthew shows Jesus as a unique teacher, and the sermon on the mount is his longest and most famous sermon. It is more than just a set of Jesus' teachings about right and wrong. It is a guide for living as a citizen in the kingdom of heaven.

Jesus described the kingdom of heaven as:

1. a connection with God,
2. a change of heart, and
3. relationships with others.

This new message of the kingdom made a strong impact on those who listened to Jesus (Matthew 7:28–29).

People often make clear distinctions between these three areas, but all are always present. For example, Jesus' instruction on humility seems inward at first, but it also involves our attitude toward God and others (Matthew 5:5). The command not to resist an evil person appears outward-focused (5:39). But it often requires active faith in God and inner strength. Jesus' instruction on prayer mainly concerns our relationship with God (6:5–15). But prayer starts with understanding that you need God's help. It also often involves your relationships with other people.

To be a citizen in the kingdom of heaven, you must follow Jesus and live a God-centered life, not a self-centered one. Trying to be righteous on your own keeps you in darkness because it is still self-focused. Jesus calls for true righteousness, which is the righteousness of God himself (Matthew 5:20, 48). You cannot achieve this righteousness on your own. Jesus gives it to those who follow him.

Passages for Further Study

Matthew 7:24–29; 13:1–52; Mark 10:14–16; Luke 8:1–3; 9:1–6; John 3:1–21; Acts 8:12; 28:23–31

Clean, Unclean, and Holy

The rules about ceremonial cleanness and uncleanness set Israel apart from other nations. One idea is that unclean things relate to death or the earth (see, for example, Leviticus 21:1, 11; 22:8). Recent studies suggest the idea of what is “normal.” God values order. Things that fit God's order are “clean” and “permitted.” Abnormal things are not suitable for food or offerings and are “unclean.”

A normal land animal would eat plants (see Genesis 1:30). A normal human body would have no infections or discharges. A normal piece of cloth would be free of mildew. If something abnormal happened, the animal, person, or cloth was unclean.

What is unclean is not sinful but represents unworthiness and cannot touch what is holy (for example, Leviticus 11:44–45). Once cleansed, it can become holy and dedicated to God. If people treat holy things, like the Sabbath, as common, they show disrespect to (or blaspheme) God and make it unholy. When something clean becomes unclean, it needs cleansing. Some things, like unclean animals, fish, or birds, are always unclean and can never become holy.

In the new covenant, things once considered unclean are now clean (Acts 10:15, 28, 45). Yet, God values order and wants orderly worship (1 Corinthians 14:33, 40). God offers grace to those who repent (turn away from wrong actions and return to God). Yet, some actions still offend his holiness and should not be in his presence (for example, Ananias and Sapphira's offering; see Acts 5:1–11).

Passages for Further Study

Genesis 7:2; Leviticus 11:1–15:33; 21:1–23; 22:3–8; Numbers 19:1–22; Deuteronomy 14:1–21; 21:1–9; Psalms 19:9; 24:3–4; 51:7–10; Isaiah 52:11; Matthew 8:2–4; John 13:10–11; Acts 10:9–28; Hebrews 9:13–15, 23

The Climax of Scripture

The gospel story of the two disciples on the road to Emmaus is important. It shows Jesus' victory over death and reveals his role as the Messiah (God's chosen one). It also connects to Old Testament prophecies about him.

The two disciples told their unknown traveling companion that Jesus was a great prophet because of his teachings and miracles. They had hoped he was the Messiah. When the Jewish leaders arrested and crucified him, these two disciples became desperate and discouraged.

Jesus scolded them for not reading the Scriptures carefully. The Scriptures had always prophesied the Messiah's suffering. The apostle Luke then describes how Jesus guided the two disciples through the Scriptures, explaining "explained to them what was written in all the Scriptures about Himself" (Luke 24:27).

Jesus does not indicate which Old Testament passages talk about the suffering Christ. But other passages from Luke's writings refer to various texts:

- Jesus is "the stone the builders rejected" that "has become the cornerstone," for a new temple of God (Psalm 118:22, cited in Luke 20:17).
- He is the suffering servant of the Lord, treated like a common criminal (Isaiah 53:12, cited in Luke 22:37).
- His opponents mock, insult, and spit upon him (Isaiah 50:6, suggested in Luke 18:32).
- He is the anointed king rejected by the leaders and the people of Israel, but declared innocent by God (Psalm 2:1-2, cited in Acts 4:25-28).
- He is the descendant of King David who God will not abandon to the grave (Psalm 16:8-11, cited in Acts 2:25-28).

According to Luke 24:27, Jesus reviewed Israel's history and showed how it anticipates and achieves its purpose (climax) with Jesus the Messiah, God's agent of salvation. This is similar to how the apostle Paul describes Christ as "the end of the law" (Romans 10:4). All the Old Testament Scriptures, including the law of Moses, the prophets, and the Psalms, show God's story of salvation (Luke 24:44). This story achieves its purpose in the life, death, and resurrection of Jesus.

Passages for Further Study

Luke 24:13-49; Romans 10:4

The Cloud and Fire

When Israel was in the wilderness, God guided them with a pillar of cloud and fire. The pillar appeared to the Israelites immediately after the first Passover, when they left Egypt (Exodus 13:20-22).

The pillar had many roles:

1. When the Egyptians chased the Israelites as they left Egypt, the pillar moved behind the Israelites and stopped the Egyptians (Exodus 14:19-20).
2. During Israel's travels, the pillar showed that "the Lord went before them" (Exodus 13:21).
3. When the pillar settled over the tabernacle and Israel's camp, it represented the Lord's presence and protection.
4. The cloud and fire also guided the Israelites when traveling (Exodus 40:36-38; Numbers 9:17-23). When

the pillar stayed still, Israel remained in place. When it lifted and moved, the Israelites followed. They camped in different places for various lengths of time, sometimes brief and sometimes long. Thus, Israel "camped at the LORD's command, and they set out at the LORD's command" (Numbers 9:23).

5. The pillar of cloud and fire was like a divine flag over the tribes as they marched (compare Numbers 10:14, 18, 22, 25).

The pillar appeared as a cloud during the day and as a pillar of fire at night (Numbers 9:15-16; Exodus 13:21). In the Bible, fire and clouds often show God's presence and glory (for example, Exodus 19:16-18; 24:15-18; Matthew 17:5; 24:30; Acts 1:9; compare Psalm 18:8-13). The cloud and fire showed that God's presence and glory traveled with Israel through the wilderness. This special appearance of God (a theophany) stayed with them during all their travels in the wilderness (Exodus 40:38; see also Exodus 13:22).

Sometimes, the cloud covered the tabernacle, and the glory of the Lord filled it, so Moses could not enter (Exodus 40:34-35). Other times, the cloud came down and stayed near the entrance of the Tent of Meeting, showing that the Lord was speaking directly with Moses (Exodus 33:7-11; compare Numbers 11:25; 12:5; Deuteronomy 31:15). The pillar of cloud and fire was a constant reminder of the Lord's presence.

We do not have a detailed description of the fire and cloud, except that it had the shape of a pillar. Yet, it was a powerful symbol of God's special care for Israel (see Nehemiah 9:19-21; compare Psalms 46:1; 139; John 1:14; Romans 8:31-39).

Passages for Further Study

Exodus 13:20-22; 14:19-24; 16:10; 19:16-18; 24:15-18; 33:7-11; 40:34-38; Leviticus 16:2; Numbers 9:15-23; 10:11-12, 34; 11:25; 12:5, 10; 14:14; 16:42; Deuteronomy 31:15; 1 Kings 8:11; 2 Chronicles 5:14; Nehemiah 9:19-21; Psalms 78:14; 99:7; 104:3; Ezekiel 1:4-5; 10:3; Matthew 17:5; 24:30; 26:64; Luke 9:34-35; Acts 1:9; 1 Corinthians 10:2; 1 Thessalonians 4:17; Revelation 1:7; 14:14-16

The Collapse of Culture

Impressive cultures with creative and skilled people sometimes come to an end suddenly and completely. When digging, archaeologists often find a layer of ash between layers of impressive artifacts. The ash shows the culture's destruction. This is one of the most troubling parts of human history.

Israel's history includes cycles of bravery and success, followed by disaster. Leaders like Joshua, Samuel, David, and Solomon brought Israel to power. Yet, the

nation often worshiped other gods instead of the one true God. As a result, God's people experienced judgment, and their culture failed.

They lost political independence and became slaves treated badly. The northern kingdom of Israel was particularly attracted to worshiping idols like Baal and Asherah. Thus, God allowed the Assyrians to conquer the northern kingdom, destroying it in 722 BC.

During the prophet Jeremiah's time, the spiritual and political culture in Judah was collapsing. Some kings, like Josiah, followed the covenant ban against idol worship and brought the people back to God. Yet, many rulers, including King Josiah's sons, did not continue these changes.

For instance, King Jehoiakim ignored his father's renewed commitment to God. He considered it as a threat to his political power. He became so opposed to the Lord that he tried to kill Jeremiah, the Lord's messenger. King Zedekiah was more fearful than opposed to change, but he also refused to obey the Lord.

God's messages through Jeremiah strongly criticize Judah's worship of Baal (Jeremiah 2:8; 7:9; 11:13, 17; 12:16; 19:5; 23:13, 27; 32:29, 35). He also criticized the immorality linked to this idol worship. Judah's moral decay and spiritual corruption, shown by its greed, hate, and violence, were obvious to everyone. The people stubbornly refused to abandon idol worship and return to the worship of the one true God. Yet, the people of Judah hoped God would perform a miracle by defeating the Babylonian army and sending it away.

They believed the temple would magically protect them. They did not realize that God hated their actions there. This quickened their destruction instead of protecting them (Jeremiah 7:4-15). They were completely unprepared for the horror of defeat in war and the destruction of their nation, capital, and temple. They did not understand that their spiritual and moral failure had already made their destruction certain.

Passages for Further Study

Joshua 1:1-9; 11:16-23; 1 Samuel 4:1-22; 2 Kings 17:6-18; 23:1-25:30; Jeremiah 7:4-15; 19:1-7; 24:1-10; 28:10-17; Daniel 7:1-8:27

The Coming of God's Kingdom

A key part of Jesus' message was that God's kingdom had come. The people of Israel eagerly awaited this reality. It would fulfill God's many promises that had not yet become a reality:

- The Holy Spirit would return, as the Spirit had in the past. And God would "pour out" his Spirit on

each Christian, fulfilling Joel 2:28-32 (see Acts 2:16-21). This means that the Holy Spirit would be given to all believers, not just to special leaders as in Old Testament times.

- Jesus would defeat Satan (Mark 3:27; Luke 10:17-18). This was already being shown when Jesus cast out demons (Mark 1:21-28; 5:1-20; Luke 11:20). Jesus' power over demons was a sign that he was beginning to overcome Satan's influence in the world.
- The new covenant promised in Jeremiah 31:31-34 would begin (Mark 14:24). This new agreement between God and his people would replace the old covenant made at Mount Sinai.
- The resurrection from the dead would produce its "firstfruits" (Mark 8:31; 9:9, 31; 10:33-34; 16:6; 1 Corinthians 15:20, 23). This means that Jesus would be the first to rise from the dead with a glorified body, beginning the process that will eventually include all believers.
- God's Anointed, the promised Son of David would come (Matthew 2:1-12; Luke 2:25-38). This refers to the Messiah (or Christ), the special leader God promised to send who would be a descendant of King David.

Jesus's birth, ministry, death, resurrection, and ascension fulfilled these aspects of God's kingdom. People must repent and trust in the gospel (good news) because God's kingdom has come in Jesus (Matthew 4:23; 6:10; Mark 1:14-15; 4:26-32; Luke 4:42-43).

When Jesus began the kingdom, everything changed in Israel. The Holy Spirit was active again, working through John the Baptist and Jesus. For those who understood, the promised Christ, or Messiah, had arrived. Because God's kingdom was present in Jesus, the disciples did not fast like the Pharisees and John's disciples (Mark 2:18-20). Fasting was not suitable because Old Testament promises were becoming fulfilled.

It was a time for celebration and feasting (Mark 2:19-20). This was because God's rule had started. People were already entering the kingdom and experiencing its signs (10:23-31; 9:1).

A future aspect of God's kingdom will happen when Jesus returns (Mark 14:25). At that time, God will judge evil and fully establish justice. Disease, poverty, and death will end. Jesus, the Son of Man, will return in glory and gather his chosen ones (Mark 13:24-27; Titus 2:11-14).

He will judge the world (Mark 8:38; 14:62; Matthew 25:31-46; 2 Timothy 4:1; Revelation 14:14-20). He will resurrect the dead (1 Corinthians 15:12-57; 1 Thessalo-

nians 4:13–5:11). No one knows when Jesus will return (Mark 13:32). His followers should stay spiritually alert and watch for his coming as they await “the blessed hope” (13:33–37; Titus 2:13).

Passages for Further Study

Jeremiah 31:31–34; Joel 2:28–32; Matthew 4:23; 5:3; 6:10; 25:31–46; Mark 1:14–15; 4:11, 26–32; 8:31–38; 9:1, 47; 10:23–25, 29–31; 13:24–27, 32–37; 14:25, 62; Luke 2:25–38; 4:18–19, 42–43; 6:20; 10:18–20; 11:20; Acts 1:6–8; 2:16–21; 1 Corinthians 15:22–28; Titus 2:11–14

The Coming of the Lord as Judge

The Bible tells us there will be a day of judgment. The book of James provides followers of Jesus with a warning and a promise about that day. James announces the Lord’s future coming as Judge (5:7–9; see also Isaiah 26:21; Micah 1:3). God, who gave the law, is the “Judge, the One who is able to save and destroy” (James 4:12). Those who oppose Jesus Christ and oppress his followers will experience severe consequences (see James 2:6–7; 5:5–6).

God will judge followers of Jesus if they do these wrong things:

- if they fail to show mercy (2:13);
- if they become friends with the world and its values (4:4);
- if they sin with their words (4:11; 5:9); or
- if they live to satisfy evil desires (4:1, 16).

God will judge them according to the law that was meant to set them free (2:12).

The Lord’s future coming affects our lives now. God already honors the faithful poor and humbles the rich who treat them badly (James 1:9–10; 5:2–3). Followers of Jesus are already God’s special people as God is restoring all things (1:18). James says we should obey “the royal law” of the kingdom of Jesus the Messiah (2:8). Followers of Jesus will one day inherit this kingdom (2:5).

The return of Jesus might not happen soon. So James encourages Christians to endure and wait patiently for Jesus’ return (James 1:3–4; 5:7–8). They will “receive the crown of life” (1:12). And they will gather the rewards of righteousness, which come from a life that is faithful to God (3:18).

Since judgment is coming, James commands followers of Jesus to “resist the devil” and “submit” themselves to God (James 4:7). We should “mourn” our sin and live with pure intentions and actions (4:8–9). We must help any Christian brother or sister who is moving away “from the truth” toward eternal death (5:19–20). Like

the prophet Elijah, we must have faith, and practice prayer and confession (5:13–18). Like Job, we must endure suffering. Eventually, we will understand the extent of God’s kindness and mercy (4:10; 5:11).

Passages for Further Study

1 Samuel 2:10; Psalms 2:7–12; 96:11–13; Isaiah 26:21; Micah 1:3; Matthew 16:27; Luke 12:35–48; 18:8; John 5:22–30; Acts 10:42; 1 Corinthians 4:5; James 5:7–9; 1 John 2:28

The Coming of the Spirit of God

In the Old Testament, the Spirit of God sometimes “came upon” people to give them power for God’s work and to prophesy (Numbers 24:2; Judges 3:10; 1 Samuel 10:10; 16:13; Ezekiel 11:5). During Jesus’ time, many people believed that the Spirit of prophecy had left Israel after the last Old Testament prophets. Yet, the prophets predicted that when God’s salvation came, he would “pour out” his Spirit on everyone (Isaiah 32:15; Ezekiel 36:26–27; Joel 2:28–32).

This prophecy first comes true in the birth story of Jesus in Luke’s Gospel. The Holy Spirit inspired prophets to witness and guided the events of Jesus’ birth.

The Spirit filled John the Baptist even before birth (Luke 1:15, 41). His father Zechariah sang a Spirit-filled hymn of praise to God (1:67). Mary, the mother of Jesus, became pregnant with Jesus and prophesied through the Spirit’s power (1:35; 1:46–55). The Spirit led the elderly Simeon to the temple to see the Christ (2:25–27). Later, the Spirit anointed Jesus at his baptism and empowered him to fulfill his role as the Christ (3:21–22; 4:1, 18).

After Jesus ascended to heaven, he fulfilled Old Testament prophecies by sending his Spirit to his disciples on the day of Pentecost. This empowered them to spread the good news (gospel) of salvation worldwide (Luke 24:49; Acts 1:8; 2:4, 17–18). In the book of Acts, the church completed its mission with the Holy Spirit’s guidance, power, and direction. The Spirit’s arrival marks the start of a new era of God’s salvation. God’s presence and power are now within and among his people through the Holy Spirit.

Passages for Further Study

Numbers 24:2; Judges 3:10; 1 Samuel 10:10; 16:13; Isaiah 32:15; Ezekiel 11:5; 36:26–27; Joel 2:28–32; Luke 1:15, 35, 41, 67; 2:24–27; 3:22; 4:1, 18; 24:49; Acts 2:4, 17–18

Community Identity

In many Western cultures, people often emphasize individual identity and personal independence. In con-

trast, many Eastern cultures, such as those in China and India, prioritize family and community relationships over individual interests. Similarly, in ancient Israel, a person's identity and importance came from their role in the community. All Israelites were expected to share the community's identity as the "children of Israel" and show the characteristics that defined the group.

In the Old Testament, God often speaks to the whole people in the singular. This emphasizes their unity. The Ten Commandments and Aaron's blessing use singular language (Exodus 20:2-17; Numbers 6:24-26). One person could represent the group, and the group could have one person as a representative.

For instance, Nehemiah asks for forgiveness of sins that led to the Babylonian exile, saying, "I confess the sins that we Israelites have committed" (Nehemiah 1:6-7). Nehemiah was the governor of Judea from 445 to 433 BC, about 140 years after Jerusalem's destruction in 586 BC. So, he did not commit those sins. Yet, in his prayer, he identifies himself with his people's sins.

In a similar way, the high priest could represent all the people on the day of atonement (Leviticus 16). Because individuals had such a close link to the community, one person's sin could become the community's sin if not addressed (Leviticus 4:3-21; 20:1-5).

In a similar way, Paul describes the Christian community as the "body of Christ" (1 Corinthians 12:27; Ephesians 4:12). Members share Christ's identity through the Holy Spirit. As the body of Christ, they show Christ's life in their own lives. Together, they reveal him to the world. The apostle Paul encourages the Galatian church to help "Carry one another's burdens" and thus follow Christ's example (Galatians 6:2; Matthew 11:28-30).

Passages for Further Study

Exodus 20:5-6, 8-10; Leviticus 4:3-21; 20:1-5; Joshua 7:1-26; Nehemiah 1:6-7; 1 Corinthians 12:12-27; Galatians 6:2; Ephesians 4:11-13

Community Responsibility: Achan's Sin

Is the whole community responsible for the wrongs of a few people?

Why did many of Israel's soldiers die at Ai due to Achan's sin (Joshua 7)? Why did the Israelites stone Achan's family with him? Understanding community responsibility helps answer these questions.

If Achan's family knew about his theft, they shared his guilt. A community becomes responsible for sin when

its members either take part in a sinful act or silently approve of sinful actions or attitudes.

What about Achan's children who were too young to understand or did not know about his theft? What about Israel's soldiers who died at Ai because Achan took what belonged to God?

To understand, we must return to the beginning.

The sin of our first parents, Adam and Eve, had at least two aspects (Genesis 3):

1. They chose not to trust God, even though they had a close relationship with him. Instead, they listened to a stranger.
2. They tried to become like gods themselves. They declared their independence from God, even though they failed.

Since everyone makes the same choice for themselves, no one is truly innocent (see Psalm 14:2-3; Romans 3:9-23). As a result, we all face the consequences of sin in the world. We might die because of another person's sin, carelessness, or ignorance, or because of our own actions. When someone drinks alcohol and drives, they can crash and kill other people. When people care more about making money than helping others, they may force their workers to work in unsafe places. When Achan sinned, others in Israel died at Ai.

This situation may not seem "fair." Yet, God promises to bring perfect justice in his own time. God's justice will come through his grace and mercy, brought to us through Jesus' death in our place (see Romans 5:12-21).

Passages for Further Study

Genesis 9:24-27; Exodus 20:5; Joshua 7:1-26; 2 Kings 14:6; 2 Kings 21:10-15; Ezra 9:6-15; Nehemiah 9:16-37; Jeremiah 31:29-30; Ezekiel 18:20; Daniel 9:4-19; Matthew 23:29-36; John 9:1-3; Romans 5:12-21; 1 Corinthians 15:21

Compassionate Healer

The New Testament often describes Jesus as someone who "had compassion." This phrase is sometimes translated as "felt sorry" or "took pity."

It appears in complex situations where:

1. Someone shows distress and Jesus resolves the distress (Matthew 18:23-26; 20:29-33; Matthew 18:27; 20:34).
2. Jesus displays deep emotion (Matthew 14:14; 15:32; 18:27; 20:34).
3. There is a contrast with those lacking compassion (Matthew 9:32-36; 18:27-30; 20:29-34).

In the Gospels, “had compassion” directly refers to Jesus, but it also appears in parables where it can refer to God the Father or Jesus (Matthew 18:27; Luke 10:33; 15:20).

In the Old Testament, God’s compassion refers to his tender mercy, most often toward his covenant people. God withdrew this compassion to judge Israel’s stubborn unfaithfulness (Isaiah 27:11; 63:15; Jeremiah 13:14). God restored his compassion when Israel repented (Deuteronomy 13:18; 30:2–3; Proverbs 28:13; Isaiah 55:7).

The Old Testament often describes the messianic age (the time when God’s chosen leader would come) as a time of God’s compassion (Isaiah 14:1; 49:10, 13; 54:8, 10; 60:10; Jeremiah 12:15; 33:26; Ezekiel 39:25; Micah 7:19; Habakkuk 3:2; Zechariah 10:6). The Gospels show this idea again, as the messianic age has begun and God’s covenant love is active in Israel once again.

Passages for Further Study

Deuteronomy 13:18; 30:3; 1 Kings 8:50–51; Proverbs 28:13; Isaiah 14:1; 49:10, 13; 54:7–10; 55:7; 60:10; Jeremiah 12:14–15; 33:26; Ezekiel 39:25; Micah 7:18–20; Habakkuk 3:2; Zechariah 1:16; 10:6; Matthew 9:35–36; 14:14; 15:32; 18:23–30; 20:29–34; Luke 10:33–37; 15:20–32

Complaints

The Bible teaches that complaining is often wrong. For example, God judged the Israelites for complaining about their difficulties in the wilderness (Numbers 14:27–37). The Job complained a lot and received God’s rebuke. But God still confirmed that Job was righteous and rejected those who tried to silence him (Job 42:7–8).

Job’s main complaint was that God did not give him a fair chance to prove his innocence. Job’s friends criticized him for trying to defend himself, but God supported Job’s innocence. In a kind yet firm way, God revealed himself and corrected Job for his excessive self-defense that implied criticism of God’s fairness. God redirected Job’s attention from his problems to God himself (Job 38–41).

Scripture requires us to rejoice and give thanks in all situations (Ephesians 5:20; Philippians 4:4; 1 Thessalonians 5:16–18). It also urges us to endure suffering and persist in prayer (James 5:10–18). If we feel the need to complain in prayer, we should follow the example of the psalms, which guide us back to God (see, for example, Psalm 13). Job’s positive example is not in his response to troubles or comforters, but in his response to God (James 5:11; Job 40:3–5; 42:1–6). In difficult and

confusing times, we can still recognize God’s sovereignty and goodness.

Passages for Further Study

Genesis 4:13–14; Exodus 16:2–18; Numbers 14:27–37; 1 Kings 19:3–18; Job 3:1–26; Job 6:1–7:21; Psalms 38; Psalms 39; Psalms 44; Psalms 73; Jeremiah 20:14–18; Jonah 4:1–11; Matthew 27:46; John 6:41–59; 1 Corinthians 10:1–10; Ephesians 5:20; Philippians 2:14–15; James 5:9–11

Complete Dedication

The Hebrew word *kherem* (related to the verb *kharam*) means something that is “specially set apart.” It has no exact match in modern English. The word can mean either to destroy something completely or to dedicate it fully to the Lord.

In the Old Testament

When Joshua led Israel into Canaan, some items were connected with false gods. These items were called *kherem* because they were opposed to the Lord. God required the Israelites to destroy them (see Joshua 6:18). Valuable metals, however, were placed in the holy place and became holy to the Lord (Leviticus 27:28; see also Joshua 6:19, 24).

The same idea applied to Israel’s enemies. They and their belongings could be “specially set apart” to God by being destroyed (Joshua 6:17–19; 1 Samuel 15:2–3). God told King Saul to destroy the Amalekites as judgment because they attacked Israel after God led them out of Egypt. (Exodus 17:8–16; Deuteronomy 25:17–19). This act showed that God curses those who curse his chosen people (Genesis 12:3).

In Leviticus 27:21 and 28, *kherem* refers to a vow dedicating something permanently to the Lord, such as land, items, or even people (see Numbers 18:14). These became “most holy” and set apart for the Lord’s service. They could not be redeemed or taken back.

God required this complete dedication or destruction when people committed serious offenses against him, such as worshiping false gods (Deuteronomy 7:1–6; 13:12–18).

In the New Testament

The idea of complete dedication continued into New Testament teaching. Paul used the Greek word *anathema* (the word the Septuagint uses to translate *kherem*) when speaking of judgment and devotion:

1. In Romans 9:3, Paul was willing to have God curse him if it would lead to the salvation of his fellow Jews.

2. In Galatians 1:8-9, the same Greek word describes the final end of those who preach a false gospel.
3. In 1 Corinthians 12:3, Paul warns that no one speaking by the Holy Spirit can say, "Jesus be cursed." This means that those with God's Spirit will not see the death of Jesus on the cross as a sign of God's rejection, as some Jews of Paul's time did. Instead, they will understand it as an act of atonement for sinful humanity, making things right between God and people.

For Christians Today

In the new covenant, Christians are not called to destroy people. Instead, God calls believers to show mercy to those who wrong them (Luke 9:51-56). Followers of Christ must "put to death" anything within themselves that opposes him (Romans 8:12-13; Colossians 3:5). Christians overcome evil not by violence, but through faith, the good news of Jesus, and love (Ephesians 6:10-20; 1 John 2:9-17). Final judgment belongs to God, who will act justly at the right time (Romans 12:19; 2 Thessalonians 1:6-10).

Passages for Further Study

Exodus 22:20; Leviticus 27:28-29; Numbers 18:8-14; 21:2-3; Deuteronomy 7:1-6, 26; 13:12-18; Joshua 6:17-19, 24; 7:11-15; 1 Samuel 15:2-3; 1 Kings 20:42; Isaiah 43:26-28; Malachi 4:5-6; Romans 9:3; 1 Corinthians 16:22; Galatians 1:8-9

Complete Destruction

See Complete Dedication.

Completion of the Second Temple

The dedication of Israel's second temple on March 12, 515 BC, was a major event for the Israelites returning from exile in Babylon. They could now worship and praise God as their ancestors did before the exile. This new temple allowed them to fulfill God's requirements for a covenant relationship. The high priest could enter God's presence to sprinkle blood once a year on the day of atonement for the nation's sins. After seventy years apart from God, he restored the covenant community.

This joyful event was not without challenges. With God's help, the returned exiles overcame sixteen years of opposition from those living in the land and Persian officials. Despite their enemies' efforts to discourage them, the Israelites rebuilt the temple. They once again established worship through patience, persistence, and strong prophetic encouragement (Ezra 5:1-5; 6:14).

The dedication of the temple shows that God can achieve his goals through a small group of people. These people focus on pleasing him and trust him to provide what they need to fulfill his promises (see Haggai 2:6-9). Instead of worrying about their limited resources, they trusted in what God could provide. They committed to honor God and keeping their relationship with him strong. God demonstrated his control over nations and his ability to influence their leaders to fulfill his plans (Ezra 5:5; 6:6-12, 22).

Passages for Further Study

Exodus 40:1-38; 1 Kings 7:51-9:9; Ezra 6:14-22; Haggai 1:8; 2:7-8; Zechariah 4:1-10; Revelation 21:1-27

Concern for the Poor

God instructed Israel to care for its people's well-being. Israel's covenant (special agreement) with God and its view of itself as a large family helped prevent claims to privilege. A family should support members in need. These members included widows, orphans, the poor, and foreigners (Exodus 22:22; Leviticus 19:10).

Farmers must leave the edges of their fields and left-over crops for the needy (see Leviticus 23:22). People in poverty should not be exploited. Instead, they must give loans without interest, or the debtor could work off the debt respectfully as a hired worker (Leviticus 25:35-42). These actions guaranteed the poor had food to eat.

The Bible first shows concern for the poor by adjusting the offering system for those who cannot afford expensive offerings. People could use birds instead of lambs for the whole burnt offering and the sin offering (Leviticus 1:14-17; 5:7-10). There were also other adjustments in the cleansing ceremonies (14:21-22). The most notable change is allowing flour as a substitute for the sin offering (5:11-13). This change meant the offering no longer symbolized giving a life for a life. This was done to help people who could not afford animals. This plainly shows God's desire for the poor to experience forgiveness of sins even if they cannot afford a lamb.

This theme continues with the prophets' concern for the poor and helpless. They called for social justice and compassion (for example, Isaiah 1:17; Amos 2:6). The prophets spoke strongly against those who oppressed the needy (see for example, Amos 4:1-3; Amos 8:4-8). God did not accept the people's elaborate worship practices if they were guilty of injustice and oppression at the same time (see Isaiah 1:15-20; Micah 6:6-8).

Proper attitudes and actions toward God and others are more important than worship ceremonies. This idea appears in the gospels' story of the poor widow's offering. Jesus praises her offering not for its monetary value, but for the devotion it shows (Mark 12:41–44). Religious practices could even prevent helping those in need (see Mark 7:9–13).

Jesus and the early Church showed concern for the poor. Jesus said his mission included bringing hope to the poor and freeing the oppressed (Luke 4:16–21). He warned against ignoring the poor (Luke 16:19–31). He said helping the poor was necessary for his followers (Luke 18:18–23). Following Christ's teachings, the early Church made sure to care for those in need (Acts 2:44–45; Acts 4:32–37; 1 Timothy 5:3–16). Like the prophets, they believed mistreating lowly people made religious practices meaningless (1 Corinthians 11:17–29; James 1:27–2:17).

God cares for the poor, a theme found throughout Scripture. Christians should adopt this same perspective towards those in need.

Passages for Further Study

Exodus 22:22–27; 23:6–11; Leviticus 5:7, 11; 14:21–22; 19:9–10; 23:22; Deuteronomy 10:17–19; 15:4–11; 16:9–12; 24:6–22; 26:12–13; 27:17–19; 1 Samuel 2:8; Psalm 10:13–18; 35:10; 68:5; Proverbs 14:31; Isaiah 1:15–17; Amos 2:6; 4:1; 8:4–7; Micah 6:6–8, 12; Mark 12:41–44; Luke 6:20; 14:12–14; James 2:1–17

Counsel from Others

The book of Proverbs teaches that having many advisors are good because they provide safety (Proverbs 11:14; 24:6). They increase our chances of success (Proverbs 15:22). The book of Job shows that advisors can also mislead, even if what they believe about God seems correct (Job 12:17; 26:3).

At first, Job's friends joined him in his suffering, sitting silently in grief for seven days (Job 2:11–13). Yet, their comfort ended once they spoke. Job's friends often talked about the biblical idea of sowing and reaping, which is an important part of the covenant (Leviticus 26; Deuteronomy 28; Proverbs 1:31; 22:8; Hosea 8:7; see also Galatians 6:7–8). We cannot dismiss their words. This is because much of what they said is correct teaching about God's nature and how he acts towards humans.

Yet, Job's friends misapplied this idea (see Job 4:8). They did not examine Job's life to find where he had done wrong and then warn of divine judgment. Instead, they ignored Job's faithful life and focused on his suffering. Then they assumed he was suffering

because of sin. God eventually called these advisors liars. This reminds us that we must correctly apply true things about God to please God and help others (Proverbs 15:2–4, 23; 25:11; Isaiah 50:4; Ephesians 4:29).

It is good to consider advice from different sources. But we should compare it with what we believe is right before God (see, for example, Acts 20:22; 21:4, 11, 13). God might use human advisors to help us understand his will. But he also guides us through his Spirit (John 16:13–15).

Jesus Christ is our “Wonderful Counselor” (Isaiah 9:6; see Isaiah 28:29). He has “all the treasures of wisdom and knowledge” (Colossians 2:3). When we support others in times of grief, we should be careful and thoughtful in applying teachings from Scripture. Often, our silent presence is the most helpful help we can give.

Passages for Further Study

2 Samuel 17:1–23; 1 Kings 12:3–17; 22:15–28; Job 2:9–10; 4:8; 12:17; 16:2; Proverbs 1:5; 9:9; 11:14; 12:15; 15:2–4, 22–23; 19:20; 20:18; 24:6; 25:11; 27:9; Isaiah 9:6; 28:29; 50:4; Romans 8:14; Ephesians 4:29; Colossians 2:3

The Creation

The story of the creation of the universe is key to the Bible's message. Understanding the first chapters of the book of Genesis is important for developing a biblical perspective of the world (worldview).

The opening chapters of the Bible address key questions: Who created the world, and why? Why is the world as it is now? Genesis answers these questions. It counters the idol worship that Israel learned from their pagan rulers in Egypt.

In the promised land, the Israelites would again be close to people who trusted in false gods and worshiped created things instead of the creator. Genesis taught Israel that the one true God created everything and has complete authority over all things. He alone deserves worship.

God changed chaos and made it the orderly universe we see today. In the first three days, he shaped the formless void into the structured universe. He created the heavens, water and sky, and the earth. In the next three days, he filled each area with life. On the seventh day, God's day of rest, he set a weekly pattern for human activity. This rest also points to the future spiritual rest God promised to those who trust in him (see Hebrews 3:7–4:11).

The creation story teaches that when God finished the creation, it was “very good” (Genesis 1:31). In

this setting, humans had a perfect relationship with their creator until they sinned and violated that bond. This rebellion against God introduced evil into human souls (see chapters 3–6). The world’s evil does not result from a flaw in creation. Instead, it comes from rebelling against God’s design and purposes.

Since the first rebellion, humans have separated themselves from the creator. They often do not acknowledge his presence and authority.

Genesis 3:7–19 shows what this separation causes:

- shame,
- failed relationships with God and others,
- disconnection from the rest of creation, and
- death.

Since then, God has actively worked in history to restore humans to a relationship with him through Jesus Christ. Restored humans become a new creation (see Galatians 6:15). Through Jesus, eternal life is available to everyone. God will renew everything one day (see Isaiah 65:17–25; Romans 8:19–22). The entire universe will be made new (Revelation 21:1).

Passages for Further Study

Genesis 1:1–2:3; Psalm 33:6–9; Proverbs 3:19; 8:22–31; Isaiah 40:26–28; 45:11–12, 18–19; Jeremiah 10:11–16; John 1:1–4; Romans 8:18–25; 2 Corinthians 5:17; Colossians 1:15–20; Revelation 4:11; 21:1–5

The Creator-King

God created and established the world. All of creation is his work (Genesis 1–2; Psalm 24:1–2; 95:4–5). He also rules over his creation, managing and caring for everything he has made (95:6–7; 96:10).

Several psalms celebrate God’s glory in creation (Psalms 8; 19; 28; 33; 89; and 104):

1. Psalm 8 emphasizes how God gives humans splendor and makes them rulers of creation.
2. Psalm 19 encourages us to think deeply about creation to gain wisdom.
3. Psalm 29 shows God’s power and the stability of his creation.
4. Psalm 33 praises God’s rule, order, and wisdom in creation, emphasizing the importance of respecting the Lord.
5. In Psalm 89, God’s bases his promise to David on his commitment to creation (89:9–18).
6. Psalms 93–100 reflect on God’s rule over the world. The earth belongs to him, and he has shown his power throughout history.

7. Psalm 104 is a hymn about creation. It turns the six days of creation into a beautiful song praising God’s wisdom.

Scripture commands all nations to acknowledge and praise God, accepting his supreme authority (see Psalm 9:11; 47:1–2, 7–9; 66:8; 117:1).

Passages for Further Study

Genesis 1:1–2:4; Psalms 8; 19; 28; 29; 33; 89; 93–100; 104; Ecclesiastes 12:1–7, 13–14; Isaiah 40:25–28; 43:15; 44:24; 51:13; Jeremiah 10:16; Acts 4:23–31; Colossians 3:10

The Cross and Passover

At the start of John’s Gospel, John the Baptist introduced Jesus as “the Lamb of God” (John 1:29, 36). This phrase might refer to the sacrificial lamb killed daily in the temple (Exodus 29:38–46). Or it might refer to the sacrificial lamb mentioned in Isaiah 53:7 (see Acts 8:32–35; Revelation 5:5–14). Both sacrifices represent rescue and forgiveness from sin.

Yet, this was not all that the apostle John intended. John presented Jesus as the Passover lamb. This lamb’s death is the central event of the Passover season (see Exodus 12:43–47; Luke 22:7; 1 Corinthians 5:7).

In the first century, Jews traveled to Jerusalem each spring to celebrate Passover and once again read the story of the exodus from Egypt (see Exodus 12–15). When God rescued Israel from Egypt, the Israelites sprinkled lamb’s blood on their doorposts. This act saved those inside each home from death (Exodus 12). Jews who came to Jerusalem for Passover needed to provide a perfect young lamb for sacrifice. The lamb could have no disease or broken bones.

Jesus used his last Passover meal to show that his sacrificial death would give new meaning to the feast (Mark 14:17–25). At his crucifixion, they did not break Jesus’ legs, which was often done to fulfill a Passover rule (John 19:31–33; see Exodus 12:46). Blood flowed freely from his wound (John 19:34). This showed that he was giving his life for others. A lamb died to save Jewish families during Passover in Egypt. Similarly, the death of the Son of God on the cross brings salvation to the world.

Passages for Further Study

Exodus 12:1–13:16; 29:38–46; Numbers 9:1–14; Deuteronomy 16:1–8; 2 Kings 23:21–23; 2 Chronicles 30:1–27; Ezra 6:19–21; Isaiah 53:7; Ezekiel 45:21–22; Matthew 26:2, 17–19; Mark 14:17–31; Luke 22:14–30; John 1:29, 36; John 19:17–36; Acts 8:32–35; 12:3–4; 1 Corinthians 5:7–8; Hebrews 11:28; Revelation 5:5–14

Curses and Blessings

Almost all treaty or covenant texts from the ancient Near East included curses and blessings. The curses focused on those who violated the terms of the covenant. Blessings are for those who remained faithful. This was especially true for suzerain-vassal (great king-lesser king or people) covenants like Deuteronomy (see Deuteronomy Book Introduction, “Literary Form”).

Deuteronomy explained to the people of Israel what God expected from them. The covenant required Israel to obey God. The Israelites promised to do this (Exodus 19:8). The section on curses and blessings explains how God would reward obedience and punish disobedience (Deuteronomy 27:1–29:1).

The text emphasizes curses more than blessings. This might be because people tend to focus more on promises than warnings. Blessings are often easier to understand. This is because they promise future safety. Judgment is less clear and needs detailed descriptions.

God emphasizes the curses to focus on the consequences of wrongdoing. The warnings Jesus gave about future events align with these warnings (Matthew 24–25).

Israel’s history shows how God fulfilled his promise of blessings and curses. When Israel followed their covenant with God, he blessed them. When they rebelled, he judged them. Israel’s rebellion is summarized in 2 Kings 17:7–20. When the Israelites broke the first two commandments, they violated the entire covenant (Deuteronomy 5:7–10). Their rebellion brought the curses of Deuteronomy 28 upon them.

Passages for Further Study

Genesis 9:24–27; Leviticus 26:3–45; Deuteronomy 8:7–20; 11:29; Deuteronomy 27:1–29:1; Joshua 8:33–35; 2 Kings 17:7–20; 2 Chronicles 36:17–21